

What does all this mean in an information era that seems to be witnessing unprecedented mobilisation among young people, a realisation that they are not just a passive market for FMCG goods, but participants and indeed kingmakers in the politics of their nation? We may overestimate the exposure or even the access of young people across the nation to mass media, but we should not underestimate their ambitions.

Young people, for long viewed as needing supervision, as sociologist Lata Narayan says, are increasingly asserting themselves against their typecasting. Western accounts of India have made it fashionable to perceive the globalised MTV urban youth as part of a gigantic universal melting pot, whose interest in politics is peripheral. But as the election of the first rock star President in America has shown this is not true even in the home of MTV. Youth turnout in the US increased to 52 per cent, and voters under 30 accounted for 60 per cent of the overall increase. In India, as these 40 snapshots of Indians under 40 show, young people are not just involved in furthering their own careers, but also their causes as citizens.

And the hunger is in the villages and small towns, where electricity is an infrequent visitor and colleges are hubs of often malefic political activity. No one is content any more to do what his or her parents did. Boxing, labelling, and sorting out by caste, age, gender or ethnicity are giving way to the desire to dream and do unencumbered by old identities. So Ernakulam district in Kerala has a woman panchayat leader, Susan

Thankappan, who has stood against the state's powerful land mafia to protect paddy fields in her area. Ernakulam is also the birthplace of actor Asin, who is at ease in Tamil potboilers as she is on the cover of glossy fashion magazines. Then again Surat in Gujarat has sent a young girl, Prachi Desai, to Balaji Telefilms to become a soap star but Gujarat is also where an MBA from San Francisco State University, Rahul Gala Shah, has returned to become a successful farmer.

In young India, there is no one truth, this or that, either or. There is one Youngistan that watches MTV Roadies, another has a student leader, P.K. Biju, who wants a paved road to make the 2-km trudge to his school easier. There is one Youngistan that thinks Buddhism is a fashion statement, and another couple, Shruti Nagvanshi and Lenin Raghuvanshi, who embrace the faith as a protest against untouchability. These are men and women who have chosen the rough and tumble of politics, set up unusual businesses, returned from the West to work in India, and used their talents to entertain and amuse. They are a microcosm of the vast young nation they belong to.

And they are citizens at a time when the world is watching how they will exercise their rights in the world's largest democracy. Everyone's eyeing the 180 million people under 35 who are going to vote this year, and the 43 million of them who will be first-time voters. Will they cold-shoulder convention or cave in to it? They are the future of India, but on their decision may well depend the India of the future.

with Purvi Malhotra

67.9% are unaware of the Internet

86.9% don't go to movie theatres, **76.8%** never listen to the radio, **4.1%** read English newspapers while **17.9%** read Hindi dailies

40.9% never watch TV while **44.2%** watch it once in seven days

25% of those between 12 and 35 are studying, while **7.8%** work as agricultural labourers and **7.4%** work in jobs other than farming



HEMANT CHAWLA